

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 1027

By Walley

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend the Freed-Hardeman University men's basketball team upon winning the 2026 NAIA championship.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that this General Assembly should salute those student athletes who, through their extraordinary efforts, have distinguished themselves as true champions of whom we can all be proud; and

WHEREAS, the Freed-Hardeman University Lions have proven themselves to be the fiercest of competitors and truly worthy of admiration by winning their second NAIA men's basketball championship in three seasons; and

WHEREAS, facing off against Langston in a rematch of the 2024 final, top-seeded Freed-Hardeman defeated their rivals 76-71 to claim the 2026 NAIA championship; and

WHEREAS, Freed-Hardeman's victory in the hotly contested title game was made possible by an 18-point and seven-rebound performance from Phil Horton, 16 points on 10-of-11 shooting from the free throw line by Jailen Anderson, 14 points by DJ McIntyre, and two pressure-packed free throws by Lane Lauderbaugh in the final seconds of the game; and

WHEREAS, the Lions won their 32nd consecutive game in securing the program's first NAIA Red Banner since 2024 and finished their season with an incredible 35-1 record; and

WHEREAS, the following players are proud to roar like Lions: Jailen Anderson, Rodney Henderson, DJ McIntyre, Caleb Thomas, Blake Dean, Rico Sain, Cam Hudson, Cade Walker, Lane Lauderbaugh, Dalton Colbert, Birman Jenkins, Sam Powell, Jake Ballard, Jamarcus Powell, Phil Horton, Eli Pounders, Aidan Farber, and Jackson Grisham; and

WHEREAS, the Lions' superb performance would not have been possible without the expert guidance of Coach Drew Stutts and his assistant, Grant Burns; and

WHEREAS, the members of the Freed-Hardeman University men's basketball team epitomize all that is good in today's student athletes, as they have achieved a premier level of success in competition while exhibiting the highest degree of character in all aspects of life; and

WHEREAS, the perseverance, determination, work ethic, and talent of this group of young men not only made possible a championship season but also surely bode well for their future success; and

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly find it appropriate to acknowledge and applaud the Freed-Hardeman Lions for their outstanding season on the hardwood; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend the players and coaches of the Freed-Hardeman University Lions men's basketball team upon winning the 2026 NAIA championship to claim their second title in three seasons and extend to them our best wishes for every continued success in all their future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.